Who we are and why we created this toolkit



Before talking about disinformation, we want to explain where we speak from

Top Manta did not begin as a clothing brand.

To understand why we exist, we need to start much earlier and ask a question:

Why does a person leave their country, cross one of the world's most dangerous migration routes, arrive in Europe and end up selling goods on a blanket in the streets of Barcelona?

For a long time, other people told our story for us. They called us migrants, undocumented, illegal, street vendors. But behind each of these words are

Before talking about disinformation, we want to explain where we speak from

people who, before migrating, had a life, a family, a profession, knowledge, a community and plans for the future.

Migration is not the beginning of our story.

Before the border

The story of many of our colleagues at Top Manta begins in Senegal.

For many communities, the sea is not just a landscape. It is work, food, knowledge, identity and a way of life. When resources disappear or livelihoods deteriorate, migration can cease to be simply a choice.

A phrase that is part of our story explains it better:

“My dream was not to become a street vendor. I am a fisherman.”

This sentence asks us to look at migration

Before the border

differently.

Before asking “Why do they come?”, we can ask what happened before, what inequalities exist between territories, who benefits from resources, and what responsibilities global economic and political systems bear in migration processes.

Arriving does not mean having the same opportunities

Crossing a border does not mean that the obstacles are over.

When a person arrives in Europe, they may face new barriers: their immigration status, difficulty entering the formal labour market, racism, precarious living and working conditions, or difficulties accessing housing and building a stable life.

So when someone asks:

“Why do these people sell on the street?”

we suggest a different question:

“What real alternatives does a person have when

Arriving does not mean having the same opportunities

they cannot access the labour market on equal terms?”

The blanket was not our dream or our identity.

For many people, it was a way to survive exclusion.

From survival to collective organisation

But our story does not end with exclusion.

In 2015, Barcelona's street vendors began organising collectively through the Sindicat Popular de Venedors Ambulants, the Popular Union of Street Vendors.

Organising meant no longer facing collective problems individually.

We began speaking in our own voices, denouncing racism, defending our rights, demonstrating, supporting one another and building networks with other people, movements and organisations.

From survival to collective organisation

This also changed our position.

We no longer wanted migrants to appear only as people about whom others decide, legislate, report or speak.

We wanted to explain what was happening to us ourselves and take part in building solutions.

Top Manta grew out of this process of collective organisation.

Creating alternatives and changing the narrative

Top Manta was created to offer opportunities for dignified work, but also for another reason:

to change the narrative about street vendors, migrants and racialised people.

For years, others had constructed an image of us.

We decided to build our own.

Clothing, design, campaigns, social media, demonstrations and talks became tools to explain issues such as borders, racism, regularisation, rights, colonialism and dignity.

That is why, at Top Manta, a T-shirt is not just a

Creating alternatives and changing the narrative

T-shirt.

It can also be a way to tell a story, challenge an injustice and propose another way of looking at the world.

Messages such as MIGRATION IS NOT A CRIME challenge the criminalisation of migrants.

Other campaigns reclaim words, images and symbols that had been used to target us and turn them into tools for asserting our rights.

This is part of how we practise anti-racism.

Why create an AntiFake Toolkit?

The internet and social media have multiplied the amount of information we receive every day.

But they have also made it easier for rumours, false data, images taken out of context, generalisations and discriminatory speech to spread very quickly.

Migrants and racialised people frequently appear in these narratives.

Sometimes we are portrayed as a threat to jobs.

At other times, to safety.

To public services.

Why create an AntiFake Toolkit?

To culture.

Or simply as people who do not belong where they live.

Top Manta knows the consequences of these narratives because we have often been their targets.

But we have also learned something else:

we can produce our own narratives.

We can cross-check.

We can ask questions.

We can provide context.

Why create an AntiFake Toolkit?

We can explain what a news story, photograph or statistic leaves out.

And above all, we can listen to the people being discussed.

This is where the AntiFake Toolkit comes from.

We do not want to provide a list of answers to memorise.

We want to share tools so that anyone, especially young people, teachers, community organisations and communities, can ask questions about what they see, read or share.

Five questions to start with

This toolkit suggests a very simple way to approach information:

PAUSE

Do not share immediately.

LOOK

Who is telling this story?

CHECK

Where does the information come from, and what evidence do we have?

THINK

What are we being told, and what might be left out?

ACT

What can we do to stop false or discriminatory information from spreading?

These five actions, PAUSE, LOOK, CHECK, THINK and ACT, accompany us throughout the toolkit.

Because tackling disinformation does not only mean discovering whether a piece of data is false.

It also means learning to ask who constructs narratives, whose voices we hear, whose voices are left out, and what consequences the stories we share can have.

Telling our own story is also a form of anti-racism

Top Manta has moved from survival to collective organisation, from organisation to creating work and alternatives, and from our own experience to a wider struggle for rights and dignity.

We are collective organisation.

We are the social and solidarity economy.

We are dignified work.

We are regularisation.

We are design.

We are communication.

Telling our own story is also a form of anti-racism

We are culture.

And we are anti-racism.

This toolkit is part of that same journey.

Because when others have told the world who we are for so long, part of the anti-racist struggle is reclaiming the right to tell our own story.